

KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 5: *Self-Hate and Self-Contempt*¹

We are now half-way through our study together, and I hope that you will give yourself the option to join Karis Fellowships by finishing the book study. Karis Fellowships is a support and training program for those who are beginning to understand the problem of neurosis and are willing to make the effort to extricate themselves from the pride system of the idealized self. In the last lesson, we were reminded that God resists the proud but gives grace to the humble. God's grace is a gift that invites human creatures into an ever-enriching relationship with their Creator. These creatures of grace are called Christians. They are learning to give up their pride system and disengage from the imagined identity of their idealized self.

We want God's support, but because our pride is set on fulfilling our search for personal glory, we want that support on our own terms. When God and life do not agree with our terms, we feel deeply upset, and we severely judge and blame ourselves for not being wonderful enough to achieve our illusions of glory. Dr. Horney calls this reaction *self-hate*. Avoiding the terrors and pain of self-hate then becomes the primary motivation for everything we do.

When you read about the characters in the Old Testament, look at how they experience and express self-hate. They attack others or invite attack; they do nothing about their problems or over-react to them; they make outrageous mistakes. They believe that everyone is against them, including God, or they arrogantly assume that they are lucky enough to risk disaster, which inevitably invites disaster. They resist change, align themselves with destructive people and lifestyles, turn to idols, become sexually compulsive, hurt their children, and even kill themselves. Isn't it startling how the Bible records the details of their self-hate? Why do humans hate themselves? They hate themselves because they have not and cannot live up to their own self-imposed standards.

With this understanding of self-hate, Nancy would like to offer her paraphrase of Romans 7:19-24. In this passage, the Apostle Paul describes his inner battle with self-hate:

"For I do not create the good that I want, but I end up achieving what I do not want, something disgusting and harmful. ²⁰If I myself am creating what I do not want, then it is not I who am laboring to this end, but it is this failure and guilt living in me. ²¹I then reveal this law: when I desire to create good, evil is right there with me. ²²I can explain it this way—I am happy with God's law within my real person, ²³but I see a second law in my bodily frame battling the law of my mind, and in that law of failure and guilt I am imprisoned within that frame. ²⁴Oh, I am such a miserable person! Who will rescue me from this body of death?"

Let's take a deep breath.

Paul has very high ideals for himself but finds them impossible to achieve. In chapter 8, however, we learn that he has finally resolved his dilemma. He doesn't find the solution in working harder at being or doing what he thinks he *should* be or do, nor in heaping more claims and shoulds upon himself and others. So, what is Paul's solution to his dilemma, and to the dilemma of every human being who seeks a relationship with God? The solution is found in the person of Jesus Christ through whom each of us is invited to have

a karis, not a legal, relationship with God. As Paul joyfully declares in the next chapter, “So then, there is now no condemnation (legal or otherwise!) for those who are in Christ Jesus.” To put it another way, when we are in karis relationship with God through Jesus, we discover that there is no occasion or basis for self-hate. As His people, we are free to make mistakes, train, learn, develop, and remodel our lives without fear of punishment or condemnation. Like healthy children, we are free to grow.

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).